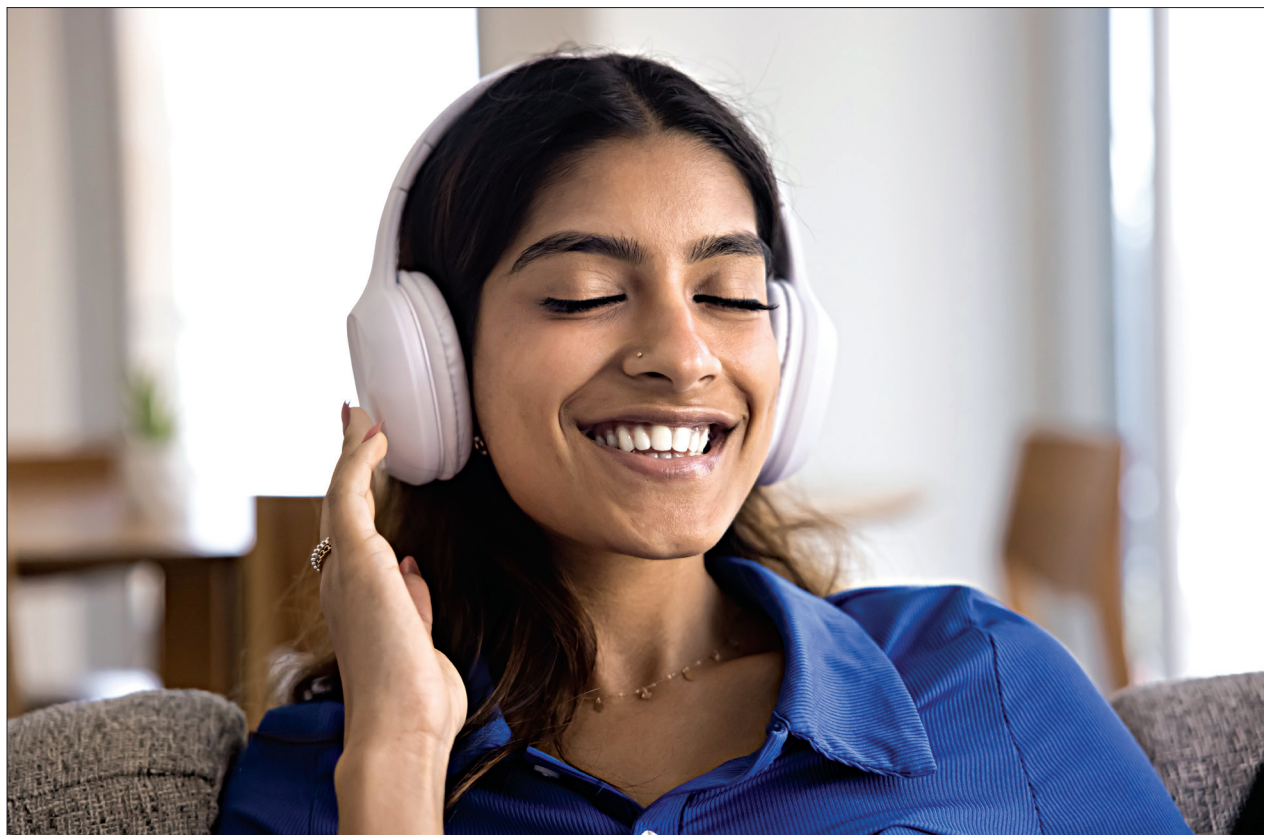




Portable listening

Choosing headphones and TWS earbuds perfectly

Portable audio has evolved from clunky wired cans to compact true wireless earbuds, offering high-fidelity sound on the go. India's headphones and earphones market reached \$4.34 billion in 2024 and is growing at a CAGR of 9.9% – driven by work-from-home trends, fitness lifestyles, and e-commerce penetration. Meanwhile, India's wireless earbuds segment was valued at \$1.04 billion in 2024 and is forecast to hit USD 1.80 billion by 2033, with fitness enthusiasts fueling demand for secure, sweat-resistant designs. Global true wireless stereo (TWS) shipments reached 78 million pairs in Q1 2025, up 18% YoY, signaling mass adoption.

In this chapter, you'll learn how to assess form factors, sound signatures, noise-cancellation technologies, battery life, and fit, followed by step-by-step selection and setup instructions tailored to Indian readers' needs.

Types of Portable Audio

1) Over-ear and on-ear headphones

Over-ear headphones fully enclose your ears for superior isolation and deep bass response, making them ideal for critical listening and travel. On-ear models sit atop the ear for a lighter footprint but may leak sound and offer less passive isolation.

2) In-Ear Monitors (IEMs)

IEMs provide precision audio with replaceable ear tips; audiophiles often prefer them for their tight bass and customizable sound tuning. They seal the ear canal, enhancing passive noise reduction.

3) True Wireless Stereo (TWS) earbuds

TWS earbuds are fully wireless, with no cables between earpieces.